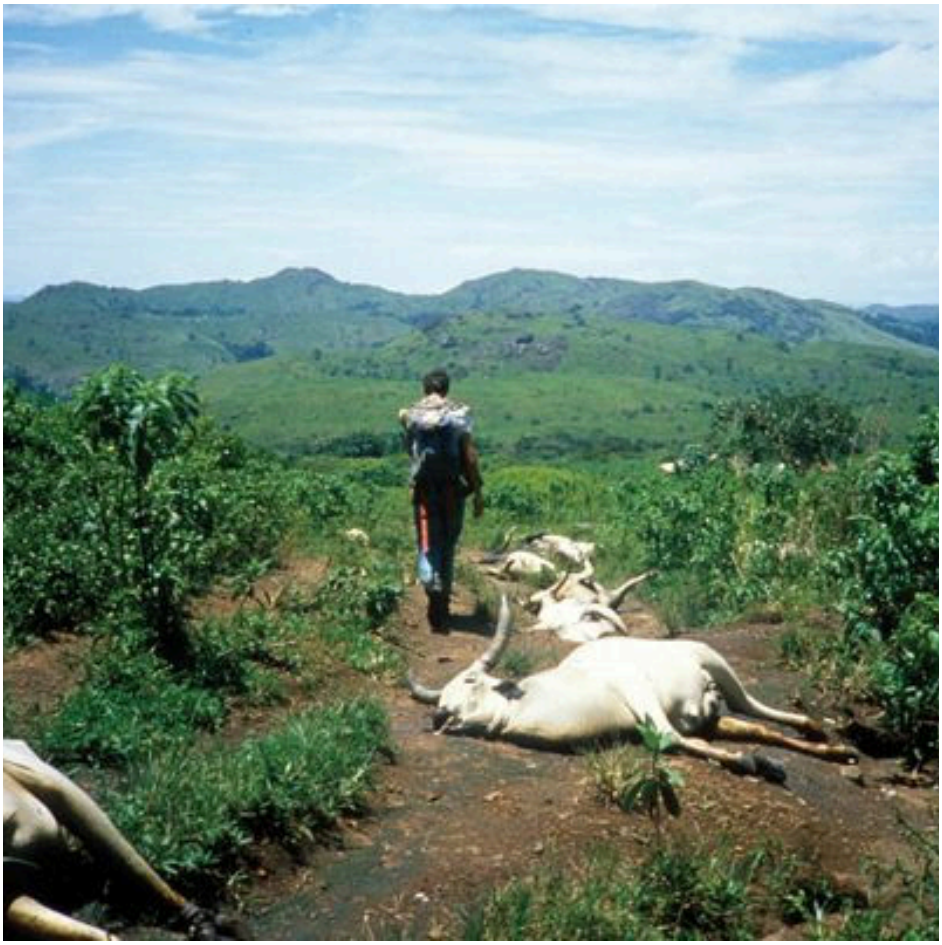
Cameroon Gazette

August 23, 1986

CLIMATE CHANGE

TRAGEDY AT LAKE NYOS





Villages Silenced Overnight

NYOS, CAMEROON – On the evening of August 21, 1986, families in the villages around Lake Nyos prepared for another ordinary night. Farmers returned from the fields, herders tied their cattle, and fires burned as meals were cooked. Children drifted to sleep under oil lamps that lit up the highland homes.

At approximately 9:30 p.m., a strange noise echoed from the lake. Witnesses described a deep rumble, lasting no more than thirty seconds. Some thought it was thunder, others said it sounded like rocks tumbling beneath the earth. Then, almost immediately, a white cloud was seen rising from the water's surface. The cloud did not rise into the sky like smoke. Instead, it moved downward, clinging to the ground as it spread into valleys and across paths.

Over 1,700 Dead

Survivors reported that oil lamps extinguished on their own, even with fuel still inside. Livestock stumbled and fell, chickens stopped mid-cluck, and people collapsed suddenly, many unable to make it out of their homes. By dawn, entire villages were silent. Families were found sitting where they had gathered for evening meals, some still holding tools or cups. Bodies were discovered along trails and near cooking fires, suggesting people were overcome within seconds of noticing the cloud.

In total, more than 1,700 people died. Thousands of cattle, goats, and other livestock lay lifeless in fields. Even birds had fallen silent, their bodies scattered across the ground. Yet curiously, the land remained untouched. Crops were still upright, houses stood unharmed, and trees bore their leaves.

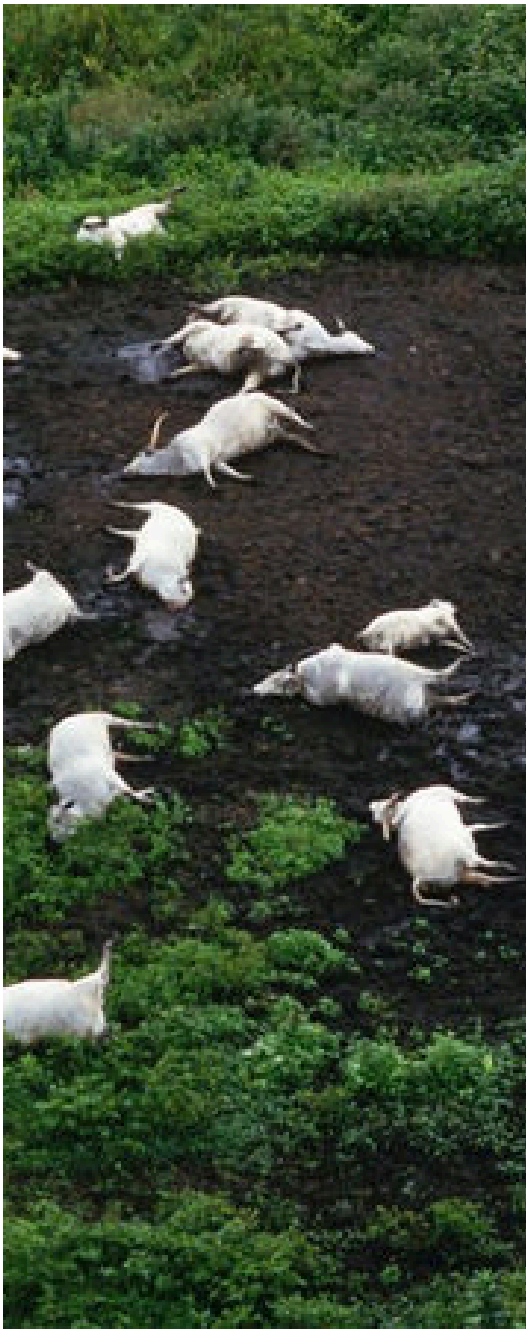
It was as though life had been erased overnight, leaving the villages intact but empty.

August 24, 1986 New York

Global Gazette

SILENT NIGHT IN CAMEROON

MYSTERIOUS CLOUD LEAVES NO TRACE OF DESTRUCTION



CAMEROON HIGHLANDS — The tragedy at Lake Nyos will be remembered not only for its scale but for its silence. On the night of August 21, villages full of sound and activity became still within hours.

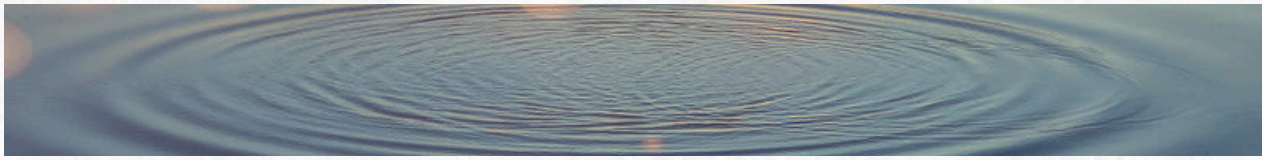
Shortly after sunset, unusual noises were heard from the lake. Some described a low roar, others likened it to underground thunder. Almost immediately, a mist formed above the water. Witnesses said it spread outward in a thick sheet, moving downhill as if pulled by gravity.

Unlike smoke that rises, the cloud stayed close to the ground. It rolled down into valleys, winding along roads and footpaths. Animals sensed it first. Cattle stumbled and fell, goats lay motionless, chickens went silent. Dogs no longer barked. Minutes later, villagers themselves collapsed in their homes and on paths.

The following morning revealed a horrifying sight. Entire families remained in the positions they had been the night before: slumped near fires, lying in bed, or stretched along roads. Survivors who awoke hours later described confusion. “Everything was quiet,” one said. “The animals, the people—gone. But the trees and houses were standing.”

Rescuers counted more than 1,700 people dead and thousands of animals lost. Yet the land showed no scars. Buildings stood unharmed. Crops remained green. Trees swayed in the breeze. The destruction was invisible, save for the silence it left behind.

For the people of Cameroon, it was a night when life itself seemed stolen, leaving the landscape unchanged but the communities devastated.



CAMEROON TRIBUNE

AUGUST 25, 1986

"I Woke to Silence": Survivor of Lake Nyos Speaks Out As told to our reporter Eyewitness Recalls Night of Horror and Loss

NYOS VILLAGE — "That night, I was sitting by the fire," recalls one man who survived the events of August 21, 1986. "I heard a noise, like thunder, but it came from the ground instead of the sky. My oil lamp flickered and went out, though it was still full of oil."

Confused, he stepped outside. "The air felt heavy. My chest was tight, my body weak. I tried to call out, but my voice would not come. Then I collapsed."

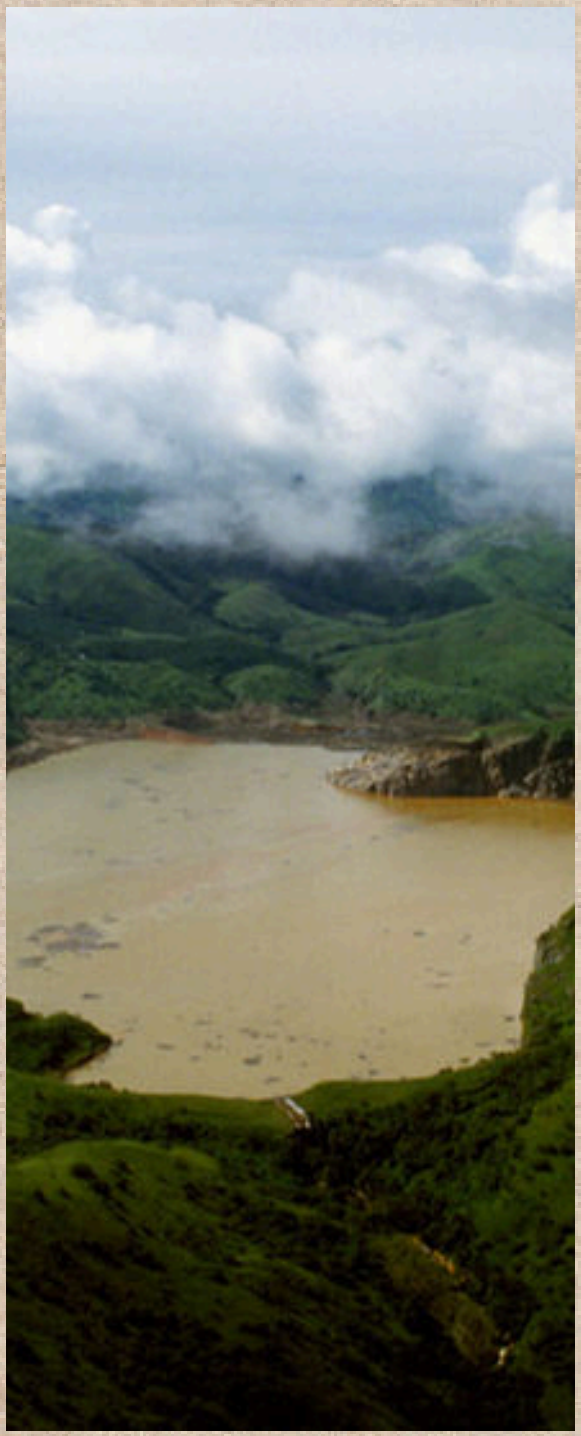
When he awoke many hours later, the world around him was silent. "I saw neighbors lying in doorways and on the ground. My cattle were gone, my family too. Everything was quiet. The houses stood. The crops were green. The sky was clear. But there was no life."

He remembers walking through the village, calling out in vain. "Everyone was gone. It was as if the world had stopped. The land was the same, but the people were not there. The silence was everywhere."

His words capture the haunting reality of a night when the land remained intact, yet communities were erased in a matter of moments.

BREAKING NEWS

MONDAY, 20 AUG 1984



A Mystery at Lake Monoun

37 Found Dead After Rumblings at Crater Lake

MONOUN, CAMEROON — In the early hours of August 15, 1984, something strange occurred at Lake Monoun, a crater lake in western Cameroon.

Residents reported hearing a rumbling noise near the lake late that evening. By dawn, 37 bodies were discovered along a roadside east of the lake.

The victims showed disturbing signs. Many had foam at their mouths, some had bloated stomachs, and others bore blisters on their skin. Alongside them were animals that had also perished: rats, snakes, even birds. The suddenness of the deaths startled survivors, who found their neighbors lifeless in positions suggesting they had been overcome almost instantly.

Despite the heavy loss of life, the land appeared untouched. Crops grew tall in the fields. Trees stood unharmed. Houses were intact. Nothing in the environment seemed disturbed—except for the silence of those who lived there.

When investigators arrived, they too reported strange symptoms. Dizziness, nausea, and weakness set in as they examined the scene. Yet no sign of fire, flood, or landslide could be found. The mystery was left unsolved.

The event at Lake Monoun foreshadowed the much larger tragedy that would later unfold at Lake Nyos.



NEWS

THE MOST IMPORTANT NEWS FROM AROUND THE WORLD

FRIDAY, AUGUST 22, 1986 SINCE 1984

The people were sleeping

On the night of August 21, 1986, in Cameroon, West Africa, 1,746 people died, most as they slept. They lived in villages around Lake Nyos. Many of the victims were found right where they'd normally be around 9 o'clock at night, suggesting they died on the spot. Bodies were laid near cooking fires, clustered in doorways and in bed. In the town of Nyos itself, virtually every soul died.

For the few survivors of the disaster, the situation they woke to was beyond terror and into the horribly surreal. Some of the survivors did not wake for two days, and when they did, everyone around them—their families and their neighbors were dead.

Stumbling out of their houses, the few survivors had thought that some otherworldly force had descended upon them and that the entire world had come to an end. Every living thing had died. Their chickens lay dead in the streets. Their livestock lay dead in the fields. 3,500 livestock died instantly that night.

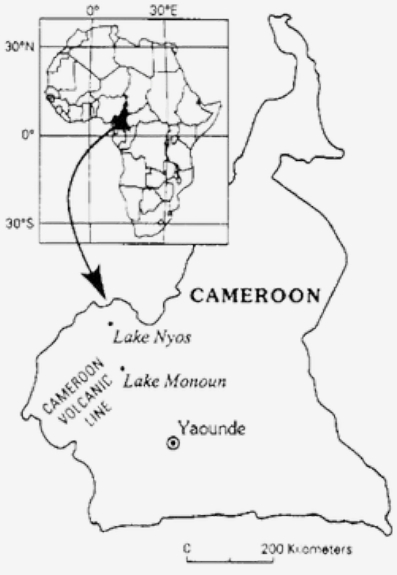
On August 15, 1984, two years before the catastrophe at Nyos, a strangely similar incident, albeit on a smaller scale, took place at Monoun, a bone-shaped crater lake about 60 miles south of Nyos. Monoun is located in a populous area, surrounded by farms and bordered in part by a road.

The lands marginal to the lakes are among the most densely populated in Africa.

"But, it was a good lake"

For some time, the cause of the disaster was unclear. Other than the bodies, everything was normal. The sun was shining. The fields were green. Buildings were not knocked down. Nothing was burned. Initially, some suspected a virulent epidemic that left only the few with natural immunity to live. But none of the outsiders and government officials who trickled into the villages became ill. It quickly became clear that something else was at play,

Rumors about the disaster arose instantaneously. Some said that plotters attempting to mount a coup d'état, or perhaps the government itself, had carried

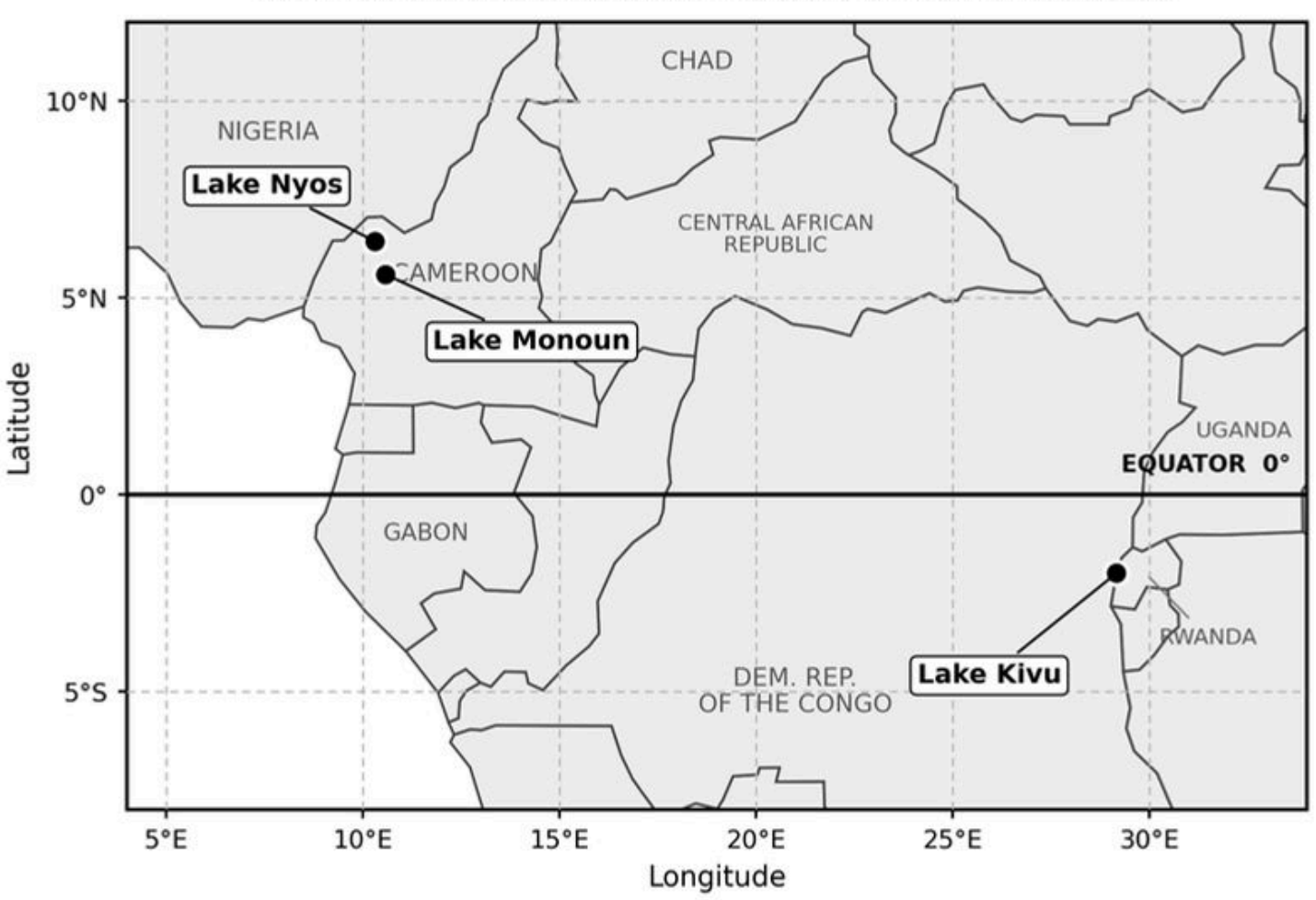


Villagers stay, despite deadly threat

"Settlers said the wish to return to ancestral lands (although some are newcomers) and the great fertility of the land as reasons for their return.

Local mythology suggests that people around Nyos have long been aware that the lake harbored destruction. Indeed, Cameroonian myths reserve a special category for lakes, which are said to be the homes of ancestors and spirits and sometimes a source of death. According to legends documented by anthropologist Eugenia Shanklin of the College of New Jersey, in Ewing, a lake may rise, sink, explode or even change locations. Certain ethnic groups decree that houses near lakes be erected on high ground, perhaps, in the collective memory, as a defense against disaster."

Lake	Latitude	Longitude	Country
Lake Nyos	6° 26′ N	10° 18′ E	Cameroon
Lake Monoun	5° 35′ N	10° 35′ E	Cameroon
Lake Kivu	2° 00′ S	29° 10′ E	Rwanda / DR Congo



Observation Lists

Lake Monoun

Lake characteristics

• 1.5 kilometers in length
• Width varies between 200 and 700 meters
• Exists in a volcanic crater
• 96 meters (315 feet) at its deepest point
• Volcanic vents at the bottom of the lake
• Small river valley at the eastern end of the lake
• Evidence of a small landslide on a nearby cliff
• Vegetation disturbed up to 5 meters above the lake's surface

Event: August 15 to 16, 1984

• Rumbling heard near Lake Monoun at 11:30 p.m.
• Event occurred in the early morning
• 37 bodies found on the road east of the lake
• Victims had skin blisters, foam at the nose and mouth, and bloated stomachs
• Dead rats, bats, snakes, and a cat found in the area
• Investigators felt nauseous, dizzy, and physically weak upon arrival

Lake Nyos

Lake characteristics

• 1,925 meters in length
• 1,180 meters in width
• 208 meters in depth

Event: August 21, 1986

• Series of rumblings lasting up to 20 seconds at 9:30 p.m.
• Part of the western cliff collapsed into the lake
• Reports of bubbling sounds from the water
• Large 25-meter surge observed on the lake
• Fountain of water burst from the southwestern shore
• Rotten egg smell reported
• Survivors noted a warm sensation before losing consciousness; many awoke 6 to 36 hours later
• Oil lamps extinguished even though they were still filled with oil
• Many wild animals had deserted the area beforehand
• Plants appeared unaffected
• 1,700 people found dead as far as 6 miles from the lake
• 3,000 cattle found dead in the same vicinity



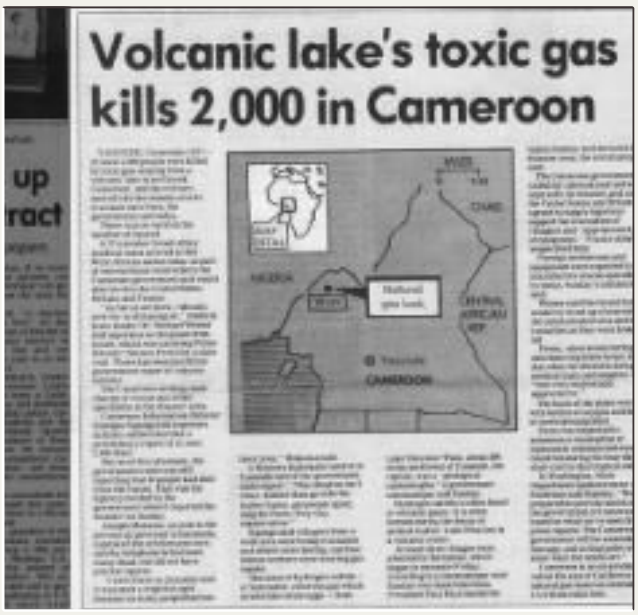












Volcanic lake's toxic gas kills 2,000 in Cameroon

